"IN THE BEGINNING..."

GENESIS 31

IN 5 MINUTES

When:

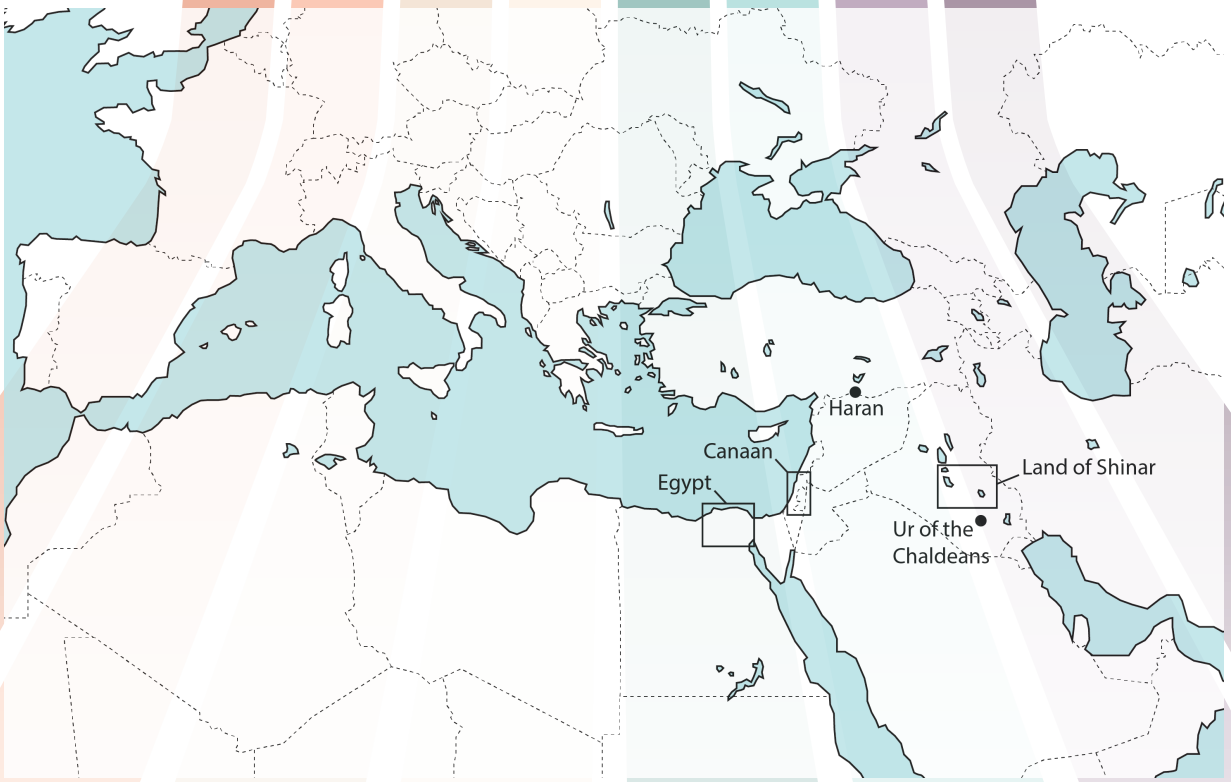
- The exact date of Jacob's return to Canaan is not known, but using information throughout Genesis, it seems likely it occurred between 1745-1725 B.C.

Characters:

- Jacob – The son of Isaac and Rebekah and twin brother of Esau.
- Laban – The brother of Rebekah who lived in Haran.
- Leah – Laban's oldest daughter. She is described as having "weak" eyes.
- Rachel – The daughter of Laban. She was a shepherdess of her father's flocks in Haran. She is described as "beautiful in form and appearance."

Where:

- Jacob lived in Haran for 20 years but returned to Canaan at the end of Genesis 31.



Outline:

- JACOB, LEAH, AND RACHEL DETERMINE TO LEAVE LABAN'S HOUSE (31:1-16):
    + As Jacob grew wealthier, Laban's sons started grumbling about him, saying he was only rich because he took what belonged to their father.
    + God appeared to Jacob and told him to return to his father in Canaan.
    + Jacob called Leah and Rachel and told them he wanted to leave.
    + He reminded them how Laban had not been honest with them in their business dealings, but how God had blessed them despite Laban.
    + He told them how the angel of the God appeared to him, just as He had in Bethel, and instructed him to make the journey to his homeland.
    + Leah and Rachel were aware of their father's dishonesty, and they agreed to return to Canaan with Jacob.
- JACOB'S FAMILY FLEES FROM LABAN (31:17-21):
    + Jacob's family quietly gathered all their belongings and fled south out of Laban's land when he was off shearing his sheep.
    + Rachel stole her father's household idols and hid them in her luggage.
- LABAN PERSUES JACOB (31:22-25):
    + It took Laban 3 days to discover Jacob had fled. As soon as he discovered it, he took his relatives and pursued Jacob's caravan for 7 days.
    + God told Laban in a dream not speak either good or bad to Jacob.
- LABAN CONFRONTS JACOB (31:26-43):
    + Laban was angry that Jacob fled in secret and didn't give him a chance to say goodbye to his daughters and grandchildren, and he demanded to know why Jacob stole his idols.
    + Jacob told Laban he fled in secret because he was afraid Laban would take his wives by force.
    + He denied stealing Laban's idols and permitted him to search his house.
    + Laban searched but couldn't find the idols because Rachel deceived him by hiding them in camel's saddle which she was sitting on.
    + Jacob became angry and berated Laban for assuming he stole the idols and for his years of dishonest during the 20 years Jacob served him.
    + He told Laban God had sustained him, even though he had ripped him off.
- THE COVENANT OF GALEED (31:44-55):
    + Jacob and Laban agreed to make a covenant of peace between them.
    + They gathered stones and made a heap and a pillar as a witness of their pact.
    + Jacob offered a sacrifice to the Lord and ate with his relatives.
    + The next day, Laban kissed his daughters and grandchildren and returned home.

Application:

- Dishonesty and deceit will keep you running from your past and will cause you to lose the things you love the most.
- Jacob had to flee his home in Canaan because he lied to his father and stole the blessing that belonged to his brother.
- Laban's family ran away from him because of his dishonesty.
- It's better to be honest and up-front in our relationships.
- Honesty isn't always easy, but it is necessary to retain the people we love the most.